



of representation the country needs.

Bad reputation

Somesh Kamra, UFC panelist at *Sony Sports India* and talent scout for the UFC in Asia, is one of them. "Until about two years ago, I was very optimistic about Indian fighters going in the right direction. But as somebody who's developing the market for a major promotion, I'm actually very, very disappointed with where we are right now," he says.

"There was a wave, maybe a decade ago, when Indian fighters were encouraged to fight at the international level, but with the expectation that they would provide an easy opponent for others. I think in the last one and a half years, I'm seeing something similar happening," he continues. "They go there with the expectation that they're going to lose. That's because their managers convince them it's a

good opportunity, and that even if they aren't ready, they will at least get the stamp of having competed at a major promotion. So they go there and lose. They might make \$10,000 for their effort. But what it does is it creates a reputation for the fighters in India. People think Dagestani fighters are so tough because the fighters from that region who have competed internationally set a really high benchmark. That's not what we're seeing in India," he explains.

While Somesh is clear that Anshul wasn't one of those who didn't deserve to fight at the international level — he considers Anshul's win at the 2023 Road to UFC one of the high points of Indian MMA — he points out that matchmakers are struggling to find suitable opponents for him. "I was talking to UFC matchmaker Sean Shelby, and he was honestly struggling to decide where to place Anshul. He faced a 38-year-old

Power punch: Anshul Jubli lands a decisive blow against Mike Breeden at UFC 294, showcasing his striking skills in Abu Dhabi. PICS: GETTY IMAGES

grappler (Mike Breeden) who was going to be cut by the UFC, and he got knocked out. He faced a newcomer from the Dana White Contender Series (Quillan) and got knocked out in 19 seconds. So Sean, as a UFC matchmaker, was honestly not sure where he would place him," Somesh says.

While Anshul was at least a legitimate winner at Road to UFC, Indian fighters have made headlines for all the wrong reasons in subsequent seasons. Last year's Road to UFC saw allegations — later proven true — that Indian fighters had padded their records. This year, Chungreng Koren, considered one of India's best fighters, had to be pulled